

We are submitting these testimonies because the people of Philadelphia are knocking at midnight.

In his sermon "A Knock at Midnight," Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. taught that midnight is not just a time on the clock. Sometimes, it is also a dark and difficult moment in people's lives. It is the hour when people are tired from a hard day's work and still feel guilty that it was not enough. It is the hour when the need for fairness cannot wait, when help comes too slowly, and when Philly's spirit starts to lose hope.

Philadelphians are knocking on our door. Now we are coming to knock on yours. You have the spiritual bread they need.

These testimonies come from the people who make Philadelphia work: the barbers, nail techs, food truck vendors, daycare providers, home health aides, house cleaners, contractors, artists, gig workers, and small business owners who wake up early, work late, serve their neighbors, support their families, and keep this city moving.

Many did not know the elimination of the \$100,000 BIRT exemption would hit them this hard. But now the impact is real. Their taxes went up. Their cash flow got tighter. Their ability to survive became harder.

Each testimony is a knock at the door. It says:

"I am here."

"I am doing the work."

"I am doing my best."

"Please do not close the door on me."

They are not knocking because they want special treatment. They are knocking because they are trying to keep their own doors open.

Bill 251026 gives City Council a clear chance to answer that knock. It creates relief for working Philadelphians who are now carrying a heavier local tax burden than many larger corporations, helping them stay in business, serve their neighborhoods, and continue contributing to Philadelphia.

Mayor Parker's Administration did the work. It prepared the fiscal note, and the Law Department agreed that this bill is constitutional.

Every day, Philadelphians are knocking.

We respectfully ask City Council to open the door, hear these voices, hold a hearing, and hold a vote.

With faith, hope, and love for Philadelphia,



liftphilly.org/petition

I am a sole proprietor and new home owner in Philadelphia. I have been operating as a sole proprietor for the past 5 years. Previously, I owed approximately \$20 annually for BIRT. This year, I **owed nearly \$9,000**. That is more than I owed the state of Pennsylvania. **This is unsustainable.**

— Rachele F. • 19148

My taxes went up more than \$7K **while corporations get tax breaks.**

— Joy M. • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19148

I run a small business in Philadelphia and actively choose to live and work here because it is my favorite city in the world. I have built my life and business here for 14 years and I am a graduate of Temple University. I am deeply invested in this community. Being required to pay approximately \$12,000 out of pocket for BIRT this year feels overwhelming and honestly shocking. For a small, virtual business without a brick and mortar location and 1 employee, this is an enormous and disproportionate burden. The requirement to prepay future taxes only adds more financial strain and uncertainty. This does not feel supportive of small businesses. **It feels like we are being pushed out.** I do not want to leave Philadelphia, but **this tax is forcing me to consider it.** I urge the city to reconsider how BIRT is applied to small and virtual business owners so that entrepreneurship can continue to thrive here.

— Emily L. • Mental Health Services • 19123

I am a single member LLC, self employed as a mental health therapist. I work with suicidal teenagers and young adults, especially from marginalized communities. My husband is disabled, so my income is what sustains my family. The BIRT should not be meant for people like me—I **am not profiting; I am simply trying to make enough to live,** support my husband and support my community. **The BIRT has drained our savings this year.**

— Megan S. • Counseling & Therapy • 19146

This year I paid over \$5,000 for the BIRT tax. When reviewing this with my financial advisor, **he immediately suggested I move out of Philadelphia.** I am a sole proprietor just scraping by. I haven't gone on a real vacation in years. The BIRT tax will force me to exit the city I've invested in for 25 years if it continues. **Is that really how Philly wants to get rich?**

— Meg L. • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19134

I tried my best to run a one-person therapy business in Philadelphia. It was a struggle for 3 and a half years, but **the changes to the business tax structure were the final nail in the coffin**, forcing me to cut my business back to the bare minimum and take a full-time job elsewhere to make ends meet. I am all for paying my fair share of taxes. I love Philadelphia and want our city to grow and succeed. But this is not the way--**small businesses can't survive** when business owners at all levels of income are paying 7 to 8 percent of their earnings to the city, between the wage tax, the BIRT, and the NPT. These changes will drive small businesses to close or to move out of Philadelphia.

— Blair D. • Mental Health Services • 19129

The BIRT tax and the requirement to pay my estimated tax for 2026 up front this year was crushing. **I'm now behind on my other bills** because I had to meet this obligation for the city. I didn't get a letter about the BIRT update until December of last year, and I had no idea that I would have to pay tax year 2026 up front. **The roll-out of this new policy has felt punishing for indie workers.**

— Alaina J. • Writing & Journalism • 19148

I'm a solo freelancer in video post-production, I gross way under 100k per year, and I can't afford this tax increase. My mind's on covering rent and groceries. **I was already paying ~30% in taxes**, and this new tax is another ~10% of my income (I have to pre-pay for next year?!). This is so, so serious. **There's no money left to bleed out of us.**

— Annie H. • post-production • 19146

This increase is unfair and unsustainable. It amounts to taking a whole week's gross income out of my pocket. I have worked as a sole proprietor in Philadelphia for over 20 years. I could have stayed completely online after the pandemic, but returned to leasing an office in Center City because I love it, and because I felt it was better for the city for us to come back and to be a part of its cultural and financial life. Now I will have less cash to spend in other small businesses in Philadelphia. **The knock on effect of this will be really significant.** Now **I am considering whether it is worth my effort to stay in business in this city.** Please bring bill 251026 to a vote and do the right thing for people.

— Laura H. • Mental Health Services • 19130

The rapid, forced imposition of these newest taxes is what makes this so unbearable. 1% over 5-6-7years is manageable, predictable, foreseeable. **Having a 5.7% tax is debilitating.** And for it to be **taxed on gross receipts and not net income is honestly asinine** and will drive small businesses out of the county. There was no way to prepare, no way to save, no way to see this coming. We were uninformed and taken advantage of as small businesses, we don't individually have much leverage. But we must all collaborate to create a stop to this - to create a better plan to raise revenue for the city while not robbing small businesses.

— Madeleine H. • Landscaping & Lawn Care • 19119

I own and operate a Catholic-based therapy practice here in Center City, Philadelphia. Prior to the changes to the BIRT tax, I have been able to provide free and low-cost therapy options for those that otherwise could not afford therapy. Due to these tax changes, **I am no longer able to give back to my community** and serve others with pro-bono/discounted mental healthcare. Additionally, I am **considering closing my office in Philadelphia** and leaving the city as a result.

— shannon C. • Mental Health Services • 19130

As a sole proprietor this tax will be devastating and if I don't relocate my business just outside the city, **I could likely go out of business.** I hear this from many others like myself and either way, the city won't be able to collect the tax anyway plus you could have more residents applying for assistance programs. \$100K for a small business with overhead and debt is still scraping by and hanging by a thread for a middle-class lifestyle.

— Justin M. • 19128

New as a small business after years as a W2 and I was shocked by the BIRT. I had no realization that partnering with a colleague as a pass-through would mean I'd even be **taxed on what I paid right out to him.** How many others aren't in a position then to pay these taxes and then pay the next year's estimates at the very same time? **It isn't a policy that supports entrepreneurial life for the smallest ventures among us.**

— Margaret B. • Business Consulting • 19119

I am an artist who has been working and selling my work in the city of Philadelphia since the 1990s. I don't make a great deal of money doing this, but what I do earn goes toward my living expenses, and BIRT would seriously impact my income. **I've done everything I am supposed to do** up to this point: I have a license and I pay my taxes; but **BIRT seems designed to punish small business owners.**

— James M. • Visual Arts & Muralism • 19147

I am a new business, in my fourth year of operation. My total gross profit this year was less than \$50,000, and **suddenly I was hit with a little over \$2,000 BIRT tax**. For small independent business owners who are trying to get or stay afloat, these taxes are a huge hit. **What's happening on the other end of the spectrum to tax large business** with gross profits in excess of \$1M?

— **Karena V. • Landscaping & Lawn Care • 19143**

I'm a single member LLC, I provide psychotherapy and I take insurance and sliding scale to make therapy accessible, which does not pay well. The BIRT tax is so much, it's **affecting my ability to continue providing affordable care**

— **Kristi S. • Counseling & Therapy • 19103**

I am being taxed out of my home and my business will not be able to remain in Philly—I will not be able to do the work of helping the people of Philly who I care so much about—if this tax remains in place.

— **JEANINE S. • Mental Health / Psychotherapy • 19103**

I have been running my business for 16 years and the taxes are making me think I cannot have my business in Philadelphia anymore

— **Ruth C. • Mental Health Services • 19107**

I am a new clinician working as a 1099 contractor at a group practice. I am not a traditional business owner- I don't have as many deductions as most businesses. I'm also dealing with student loans, paying for my own health insurance and earning my hours towards independent licensure. I will be leaving philly instead of opening up my own practice here as previously planned solely because of the BIRT change. It has made it impossible for me to save anything, I'm living pay check to pay check while trying to support others with their mental health health. It's making it incredibly difficult to manage my own. I feel hopeless about the future.

— **Meg C. • Counseling & Therapy • 19130**

The removal of the BIRT exemption is disproportionately impacting mental health practitioners in private practice, most of whom are sole proprietors who make less than \$100k. Extrapolating from national stats, private practice therapists make up HALF of the entire mental health field in our city. Private practice psychotherapists like me offer an essential service to our city's economy. We stabilize working people, prevent crises from worsening, and keep people in their jobs and family lives. Today, about 20% of adult Americans suffer from some sort of mental illness, and Recent research has shown that untreated mental illness among Americans, namely workers, cost the US economy about \$282 billion a year. But the BIRT tax exemption removal has raised the taxes on my small business by a factor of 6. BIRT has made me, and every colleague of mine in a similar position I've spoken to, seriously consider moving my small business out of the city.

— **Lillian D. • Psychotherapy • 19143**

I have had my clinical psychology practice in the city of Philadelphia for 36 years. This year made my BIRT tax went up by a factor of six. It is leading me to consider the longevity of my practice .

— **Dr B. • Clinical psychology • 19130**

My counseling practice provides needed services to Philadelphians, including people on Medicaid. These tax changes are making it significantly harder for me to keep my practice open.

— **Patrick G. • Counseling & Therapy • 19119**

I love Philadelphia and want to be able to run a successful business here

— **Mattea L. • Counseling & Therapy • 19146**

The BIRT is making me consider relocating my business and where I live. I love Philly so much, but this makes me strongly reconsider.

— **Brittany W. • Mental Health Services • 19102**

I was an independent contractor for years and it was difficult to pay taxes and all other expenses. I want to stand with my fellow Social Workers who have to pay this unexpected tax.

— **Samantha R. • 19152**

I own a solo practice providing individual, couples and family therapy. I'm a single income household. I make under \$100,000 a year and have no benefits i.e. no paid leave, vacation, workmans comp and I have to pay my mortgage, utilities, nearly \$900 a month for health insurance from Pennie, student loans, and in the 4.5 years of living here my property taxes have nearly doubled. As a 1099 I already have to pay 7.65% more social security taxes than a W2. In 2024 I made \$11k more than 2025 & I had to pay around \$3,200 for NPT to the city. Now for 2025, with the new BIRT tax I had to pay almost \$5,000 between BIRT and NPT. So I made \$11k less and had to pay around \$1800 more in philly taxes then the previous year. Offering a grant that we can apply for that only covers business expansion costs does not help me pay my mortgage or health insurance. You are going to lose many therapists at a time where you need more MH workers because we can't afford to live or our have businesses here.

— **Lydia B. • Mental Health Counseling • 19128**

I budgeted especially carefully this year in order to pay my bills in spite of (unpaid) maternity leave. I kept up with quarterly estimated taxes, even for the period during which I had no income. And then was hit with a devastatingly high tax bill that I did not expect or understand. This tax makes it hard to feed my family or stay in business. Please reconsider.

— **Nomi T. • Counseling & Therapy • 19143**

I want therapists to be incentivized to stay in Philadelphia and provide much needed mental health services to our communities rather than relocate to the suburbs.

— **Amy S. • Counseling & Therapy • 19123**

This changed drastically impacted my taxes. If not changed back, I will move my business out of the city once my lease is over.

— **Christopher W. • Mental Health Services • 19018**

I am a small business owner and a parent of two young kids. Having to pay local tax that is essentially two times more than the state tax liability has put a significant burden on my family and will impact our ability to keep living and raising our children in Philadelphia. I hope that our collective concerns will be taken seriously!

— **Valeriya S. • Mental Health Services • 19130**

My husband and I actually both have small businesses- his is doing SEO work for small companies. Combined, we owe over 6k this year and will need a payment plan to pay it all-plus interest. We are getting advised to live or work outside of Philadelphia despite being here since 2016. I work in underprivileged schools and with low income children with special needs as a contractor.... this type of tax will crush both of us and force us out of valuable working helping children, families, and other small businesses in my husband's case.

— **Aleksandra B. • school and private speech therapy services • 19151**

I just opened my business in January 2025. If I had known about this tax, I wouldn't have opened it here in Philly. Shame on this tax bill.

— **Cassidy F. • Mental Health Services • 19121**

An increase in taxes would impact my ability to sustain my practice and continue providing services.

— **Jamica C.** • **Counseling & Therapy** • **19114**

This large tax increase for the smallest businesses and gig workers isn't healthy or right. I'm facing a difficult decision to leave the city in order to sustainably continue as a sole proprietor.

— **Kasryn k.** • **Mental Health Services** • **19131**

Its ridiculous that I cant even make a living helping people when now the city wants to charge us a tax on our services

— **Kathryn E.** • **Counseling & Therapy** • **19146**

This gives an additional reason to leave the city...

— **Eli S.** • **19063**

This puts an undue burden on people who barely are making enough to pay bills as it is. It seems correct to me that once you make over 100,000, then you start paying this tax.

— **Erika B.** • **Mental Health Services** • **19143**

I've been doing this 15 years it's astronomical!

— **Stephanie M.** • **Pet Care & Dog Walking** • **19122**

I'm signing because many of my neighbors are small business owners with very small margins. Companies like Amazon have already made it so much harder for small business to thrive, we should be doing everything we can to support small business owners in Philly to thrive! Small business owners are actually part of our communities, the money they earn stays in our community. This helps everyone! If you want to raise taxes, raise them on Amazon, Walmart, Target, CVS, etc...

— **Kristen S.** • **19134**

I have a small therapy business that is less than two years old. I make such little income yearly and paid so much in taxes this year. I do not know how this can be sustainable for my business moving forward with all of the expense I already have.

— **Jennifer** • **19121**

I've been laying the BIRT for years. Paying it double for the first year was a slap in the face, as it continues to be for every year I earn more than the previous year. As a sole proprietorship it's absolutely wild I should get taxed double or quadruple as much as someone paying the wage tax just because I generate my own income. All because someone with barely any standing decided to sue because other people got a tax break? Ridiculous.

— **Daniel P.** • **Theater & Performing Arts** • **19134**

I am a second career graduate student about to enter the field of mental health counseling. My partner has a small business that offers bookkeeping and tax prep services. This tax hasn't affected me yet, but it will. We have already started conversations about whether this tax, among other taxes, is enough for us to consider moving out of the city. We don't want to, but we are worried.

— **Tara R.** • **Counseling & Therapy** • **19104**

This is my newest business but i also own another business unrelated but this is affecting both.

— **Stephanie N.** • **Salon** • **19107**

I am a solo business owner, already feeling the tax burden of living and working in Philly. But I love it here and it's always been important to me to invest in and work in the city where I live. This recent BIRT increase was an alarming shock to my system. I already run on pretty thin margins to be able to do the work I do and earn a living. The city and all of us as community members benefit from small businesses staying here in the city - laws like this make it exponentially less possible to do.

— Erin V. • Counseling & Therapy • 19102

I love working, living, and serving the people of Philadelphia and I want to continue to do so in a way where I can thrive and sustain.

— Shara H. • Mental Health Services • 19144

As a small business owner, the new BIRT tax plus the estimated taxes, in addition to the high taxes we already pay are unaffordable and impossible to manage.

— Kimberly K. • Mental Health Services • 19119

My family has been housing providers in the city for over 20 years providing safe and affordable housing.

— Devi • Housing • 19151

My family has been housing providers in the city for over 20 years providing safe and affordable housing.

— Mayur J. • Housing • 19151

My family has been housing providers in the city for over 20 years providing safe and affordable housing.

— Kaushal J. • Housing • 19151

Small businesses are a large part of what makes this city special and we need to stop making it so hard for them to survive before we're left with nothing but chains.

— Brad W. • 19146

I am a contractor for the early intervention program in Philadelphia. This tax has made it difficult for me to continue to serve our cities students.

— Jenna B. • 19001

Protect small local business from debilitating and unfair taxation.

— Dominic A. • 19001

I support Philly's Mom and Pop Business Owners — the gig economy.

— Larry D. • 19130

To support a friend working in Philadelphia

— Juliane S. • 18966

Concern that this tax will drive small businesses out of the city and lowering tax revenue and making it harder for people to find needed services.

— Dominic A. • 19111

I'm a self-employed artist. And I'm a self-employed tax preparer who prepares taxes for self-employed artists and creative professionals. This year has been heart wrenching for me, as I've had to explain the BIRT changes over and over again to people just scraping by. We all love our city and choose to stay here and work here - but we need a tax structure that will lift us up, not grind us down.

— **Maria M. • Tax Preparation • 19148**

My husband is an independent contractor so this extreme tax hike affects me as well. He's been doing this for over 10 years and wants to continue doing so, but if we can't move outside the city this year to avoid this drastic increase, we're done for and he's out of work.

— **Sara S. • 19146**

As a freelancer, I am hired to perform the same job during the same hours as full-time employees (because it's cheaper for the business I am hired by), except I don't get benefits or healthcare. I am not a business in the general sense of the word, I just get paid my wages on a 1099. I already pay city wage tax and self-employment tax on my income, now without the BIRT exemption my tax burden on that same income has gone up thousands of dollars. BIRT is a punishment on top of an already disadvantaged employment situation. I can't imagine how this is affecting people who are scraping by.

— **Jessie A. • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19145**

I literally just started my business this year and this tax will be detrimental

— **Rachael A. • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19145**

I respect the work it takes to have a small business. I do not approve of this additional burden.

— **Carmen M. • 19063**

I'm new to the city and was so excited to move here and conduct my business here. This tax has been a huge hit to my business and making me consider moving out of the city.

— **Brianna M. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19145**

We have been hit hard in the past 6 years from Covid closures, hurricane Ida, rising economic costs, and now being unfairly taxed. We want to be able to pay our employees and ourselves a livable wage sustainably, and give back to the citizens of Philadelphia.

— **Tracey T. • Personal Training & Fitness • 19127**

I cannot afford this tax and neither can any other freelancer in this city!

— **Kim K. • 19145**

BIRT taxes will ruin the city's early intervention system, which is primarily sole proprietor independent contractors.

— **Mindy K. • Occupational therapy, early intervention • 19139**

So many small businesses are closing. Every third storefront in Philly is closed and depressed. Signing this to put an end to it!

— **SARAH F. • 19145**

I've run my consulting business in Philadelphia for 7 years. This year my tax accountant said I should move out of Philadelphia because it is too expensive to keep my business going here. I am still not sure how I will be able to pay the 2025 and 2026 BIRT bill, for now I am on a payment plan.

— **Selina M. • Videography & Film • 19139**

I am a small business and this years tax bill (BIRT) really hurt and negatively affected my livelihood..

— **Ruth B. • 19147**

This is harmful to the success of hard working independent people

— **Alyse B. • Artist • 19147**

I can't continue paying our so much in taxes for so little support

— **Netanel P. • Visual Arts & Muralism • 19130**

Philly can do better for its citizens and small business owners.

— **Emily B. • 19134**

I don't want Philly punishing creatives!

— **Brendan B. • 19146**

As a single person LLC I try to keep my overhead really low in order to survive. This tax really is an undue burden and becomes one of my largest expenses for the year.

— **Doren D. • Massage Therapy • 19103**

This is an unfair tax on sole self employed who every day "eat what they kill." Big corps get a better deal.

— **Lisa B. • 19114**

It is extremely hard to be an independent performing artist at the best of times. An additional tax burden is an insult, considering we are at the very bottom of the payscale. Tax wealth, tax big corporations, tax second-home-owners, tax people who can spare it!

— **Larisa M. • Live performance • 19143**

I have had my business for 17 years now and am proud to work and live in Philly. We raise our kids here and send them to Philly public schools. As a parent and also a caregiver to an elderly mother with Alzheimer's, it is important for me to have a flexible schedule and to keep my business running in a way that allows me to maximize my time and the support I offer to my clients, while being available for my family's needs. I do this work because I care about people's mental health. Additionally, it is an essential part of my business practice that I be able to offer clients a sliding scale fee for therapy - I prioritize offering reduced fees for folks who financially cannot afford treatment and/or for folks who give back in some way to the community. This new tax scale is a hardship to those of us who have small businesses and big family and community responsibilities! And I'm very frustrated that businesses with lots of revenue have so little tax liability in the city that I love.

— **Margaret H. • Mental Health - Private psychotherapy practice practice • 19147**

I've been working as a freelance writer, communications consultant, and artist and paying taxes in Philly for more than a decade. I have recently begun looking for full-time work in part due to Philadelphia's excessive taxation on freelancers, which makes self-employment simply unsustainable in this city. Despite the high taxes I pay, I've seen little progress in those taxes going towards things that matter to me, like clean streets free of garbage and unsafe sinkholes and potholes, increased funding for arts and culture, more protected bike lanes, and more research into (and mitigation of) the impact of PFAS and toxic waste in our waterways. I hope City Council will take the impact of BIRT on self-employed workers seriously. It is unfair to ask the self-employed to front this money when we already pay self-employment taxes while receiving no unemployment benefits if our work dries up, and bearing the cost of all of our own benefits. Thank you for your consideration.

— **Nicole Q. • Communications and Arts • 19148**

Been a sole prop. In phila for 25 years

— **Laurel M. • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19148**

I have been a freelance artist for most of my life. The wages that I make in my field are not enough to live on. Additional taxes are not at all helpful. Small businesses in Philadelphia should not have to pay additional taxes as I am sure we are all still struggling since the pandemic and affected by the adverse economy more than any large corporation.

— **Cybele M. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19144**

The BIRT increase hit my business and my family hard this year, especially given the estimated tax requirement for 2027. I made it work but many other business owners in this city cannot and there's no excuse for the city not to find a solution.

— **Caroline W. • Business Consulting • 19145**

This affects my friends and neighbors. I love all the small independent business and would hate to lose them.

— **Zoey G. • 19134**

I've been doing tax prep for artists for about 20 years, and I've seen many changes to our local tax code -- some good (the \$100k exemption for BIRT, getting rid of the one time cost for the commercial activity license), some bad (the terrible portal, getting rid of the \$100k exemption). I'm worried these new BIRT rules will drive artists out of the city I love. For low income artists running their art practice as a small business, the BIRT is so burdensome.

— **Amy S. • 19103**

My wife is a small business owner and due to the BIRT we will have to relocate our family.

— **James F. • 19134**

I've been working as a freelance theatre artist for 15 years. Having to pay this tax makes it significantly harder to live.

— **Cat R. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19143**

Arts workers are already underpaid and under resourced by the city, while wealthy developers, corporations, and universities benefit. Now the city is taking more of my money, but I don't get the benefits!

— **Daniel P. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19143**

This double taxation is a burden on independent contractors like myself who are already feeling the pinch from an unsteady market. Philadelphia needs to support it's small and independent businesses, not bleed them dry. Without these businesses, neighborhoods will lose their community lifelines and be at the mercy of large corporations that care about profit over people.

— **Alison B.** • **Media and Consulting** • **19114**

The BIRT has made me question my community based small business and whether I can keep it going.

— **Petra A.** • **19125**

This is a burden on me, my family and my very small business.

— **Rachel K.** • **Graphic Design & Visual Art** • **19143**

Because our survival is seriously being threatened!

— **Tracey o.** • **19130**

I started dog walking/pet sitting a few years ago because the job market was (and still is) bleak and I could apply what skills I did have to freelancing here in the city to survive. My "business" is just me - I do this to put food in me, to make sure I can keep shelter - that I finally have after years of couch surfing (i.e. being homeless) due to a consistently terrible economy for the average working person. My AGI is about \$30K and I'm expected to pay nearly \$4K to the city in just BIRT taxes on top of the thousands in other taxes I have to pay? While food & shelter is increasingly expensive and I've cut my food intake due to not being able to afford to feed myself properly? On top of which, we already have plenty of tax money, it's just a *lot* of it is going to PPD, which is unnecessary. Philly, like most cities in the US, have been defunding education over time and increasing policing budgets instead, which does nothing for public safety - investing in community/resources does.

— **Juliana F.** • **1099 / Freelance (Other)** • **19145**

I am still developing my practice and growing my business. The BIRT tax was 3x what I paid the state this year. Times are already tough economically and this felt like a punch in the stomach.

— **Benjamin T.** • **19146**

I have a very small business and high taxes really cut into my small profit margin.

— **Stefanie K.** • **1099 / Freelance (Other)** • **19148**

Entrepreneurship is the soul of any municipality and the city administration should be ashamed for working against it.

— **Owen M.** • **Mental Health Services** • **19148**

I was an independent artist and non profit worker for 15 years in Philadelphia and know many who presently are — freelance and independent workers are the backbone of Philly and deserve essential support, not higher taxes.

— **Jill H.** • **19129**

I owe the city so much more this past year then my first year of business, and I have yet to hit the 100,000 k in profits.

— **Brianne S.** • **mental health** • **19144**

The taxes are unfair to small business owners

— **Quinn B.** • **Education** • **19143**

As a small business, this tax really hurts especially with paying the estimated tax in advance. The city is showing that it's not interested in helping smaller businesses grow.

— Jay S. • 19128

No one should have to fear how much tax increases will affect their daily lives.

— Alicia G. • 19145

My wife runs her own small, solo private therapy practice and I am currently disabled. The extra tax burden from this BIRT disaster makes an already stressful life that much more unbearable.

— Michael M. • 19146

The changes to BIRT affect me and other self-employed and freelancing workers in a way that punishes us for pursuing engagement with the arts ecosystem of Philadelphia and could ultimately create an environment in which artists and creatives begin to move out of the city for more hospitable living and working conditions.

— Joseph A. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19144

My husband is an independent contractor, so this change affects our family directly. As an environmental writer and educator, he is responsible for helping to protect our vital natural resources. In addition, I have worked independently as a theatre artist in the past and likely will again, which means this change could affect both of us in the future, further impacting our tax liability and straining our family's finances.

— Gwen N. • 19139

I am a lifelong Philadelphia resident and small business owner. With the removal of the BIRT tax exemption and U&O tax exemption Philadelphia has laid a huge double tax burden on small businesses in the same year. It is so bad that I am contemplating moving out of the city and selling my properties. Small businesses are what help to drive the uniqueness and diversity of the city. Exempting sole proprietorships from BIRT tax will help to maintain this diversity which makes Philadelphia a great place to live.

— Ian K. • Real Estate • 19121

I am an independent choreographer and dancer working between Philadelphia and Bulgaria (where I am from). Historically, Philadelphia has been one of the most important centers for the development of contemporary dance styles. Here, world-renowned artists lived and worked to hone their craft. As the city with the most theaters per capita, it is imperative to continue to support independent and freelance artists.

— Zornitsa S. • Dance & Movement • 19125

I have friends who are now financially devastated by losing the exemption. Tax the rich! There's no reason this should apply to people that are struggling.

— Timothy B. • 19121

We should be helping small businesses thrive instead of focusing on them to generate wealth for the city. I believe the city's strategy needs assessment and redirection.

— Shannon M. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19106

I am an independent contractor and already carry many burdens. I don't have paid time off, vacations, retirement accounts, or company provided health care. This BIRT tax is an additional expense that keeps me financially in the red.

— George P. • process server • 19114

I relocated my business after a decade in Philadelphia, largely because of the burden of both the high taxes, but also huge admin burden of the returns, and the difficulty in dealing with the city departments. I am hiring and employee in Philadelphia, and nearly rethought a truly excellent hire because the city taxes and the administrative burden are SO HIGH. It's a notoriously unfriendly city for small businesses like mine, and I really hope the city takes serious steps to remedy the changes to BIRT. They are unfair and unsustainable.

— **Katharine S.** • 19125

Less taxes on small business

— **Daniel K.** • Music & Performance • 19144

I have lived in Philadelphia for most of the last 26 years and have owned property in the city since 2003. I started my solo consulting practice almost 5 years ago. This year was my first year paying BIRT, which almost tripled my city earnings tax payments over the prior year. I see my taxes go up every year on everything, and yet, little to no improvement in City services or quality of life. Enough is enough. Stop trying to balance this city's budget on the backs of its workers and small businesses and tax the developers, corporations, and wealthy more!

— **Michele W.** • Business Consulting • 19123

I am a brand new business owner and these kinds of taxes bury me! Adding these kinds of taxes kills new small businesses and work that could bring new money and life to the city.

— **Stefanie L.** • Business Consulting • 19106

Taking more money from the working class is not the way to increase city revenues and you know it.

— **Timaree S.** • 19103

I've lived and worked in Philadelphia since 2002, and I need to be able to afford to run my business here. I'm an executive coach, and the repeal of the tax exemptions has been beyond brutal, making me look into alternative locations to move my whole family to. I don't want to leave, but I many not be able to afford to stay if City Council doesn't find a way to mitigate this tax mess.

— **Veronica S.** • Business Consulting • 19126

This affects all of us average joe blokes

— **Darien J.** • Industry business • 08060

I'm lucky enough to have a W2 paycheck right now, but I'm 50 years old and have worked most of my career on 1099s. This is not just about small business owners or tradespeople with contracting businesses. Lots of people who earn money as 1099 workers are scraping by on gigs; lots of them have a regular job where their company pays them on a 1099 basis (whether it's legal or not). I never owned a business, but I've been a freelancer for most of my life. The way this city taxes regular working people is absolutely terrible, and it got worse last year. The old \$100k exemption was a small step toward fairness, but it wasn't enough. I understand that the legalities of this are tricky. This bill is not enough either, but it seems like a good start.

— **David S.** • 19145

Small businesses need are a vital part of the city and will be even more important to the city's future than before with the rise of AI. We need to relieve the pain, not add to it.

— **Vince Q.** • 19130

I am a new business owner - it is just me and I advise and assist nonprofits on their strategy and program development. Given the nature of my work, I do not make a lot of money doing this and this tax has made my finances even more challenging. Please consider returning the \$100,000 BIRT exemption. Kate

— **Katherine • Business Consulting • 19148**

Support small businesses.

— **JOSHUA V. • Vinyl Record Sales (online) • 19126**

I run a business here

— **Katerina • 19106**

The new BIRT bill is bad for my biz, bad for me, bad for the city. Please fix this injustice. TYIA!

— **Anne G. • 19147**

My business is 10 years old and this seems like the highest tax bill received to date despite it not being a particularly profitable year.

— **Corey A. • IT & Tech Support • 19123**

Freelancers shouldn't have to pay a higher tax rate than regular corporate employees. Also, the BIRT requirement that the next years tax has to be paid entirely before the money has even been earned, is just crazy. Most freelancers don't have the money upfront and cannot predict how much they will make.

— **Patrick F. • 19147**

I just transitioned from full time work to freelance. The flexibility suits our family's needs with two children. The unexpected tax payment was an unfortunate strain on an already small amount of income to start.

— **Samantha S. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19147**

I'm signing because everyone deserves a fair chance to survive in this already messed up economy

— **Marcy A. • 19134**

i have two small businesses that are difficult to make a profit from. Anything that raises my taxes makes it even harder. I'm a technology writer and a fine arts painter. My professions add flavor and style to this city.

— **Deborah R. • Writing & Journalism • 19132**

I work with many local creators and makers who are directly affected by this tax

— **Robert P. • Restaurant & Hospitality • 19147**

We have members who are small mom and pops in this industry who is going to get affected by this very drastically, so we request to protect the people who make Philadelphia work.

— **Priya • Real Estate • 19103**

As a former freelancer in Philadelphia I know how hard this city makes it to be an independent contractor.

— **David D. • 19106**

I've been in business for 7 years and this tax is hitting me hard at a time where cost of living, health insurance are skyrocketing. Please protect small businesses !

— **Deborah R. • Mental Health Therapist • 19130**

I've been a landlord for 42 years in Philadelphia. I'm a sole proprietor and I work hard to give my tenants a decent place to live. I need the BIRT exception.

— **Katherine D. • Real Estate • 19147**

I'm signing this petition because the cost of living in Philadelphia continues to rise while wages are not keeping up, and it feels like that reality is being ignored. Even after working hard to increase my income, I still feel like I'm back at square one financially. The constant financial pressures and added costs in this city make it harder and harder to actually get ahead. If I'm feeling this strain while earning above the average household income, I can only imagine how difficult it is for those making significantly less; especially individuals who rely on gig work or self-employment to survive. Removing the BIRT exemption only adds another layer of financial pressure to people who are already doing everything they can to make ends meet. I don't want to see families struggling to afford basic necessities like housing, food, and childcare. Philadelphia should be a city where hard work leads to stability, not where people are taxed further into financial stress.

— **Cierra C. • 19134**

I work really, really hard to pull together about \$80k in NEC, out of which I need to pay for continuing education and office space and electronic systems to maintain confidential client records. I need to pay for an overpriced pennie insurance. The previous exemption made it possible to survive as a solo private practice therapist.

— **Leslie S. • Mental Health Services • 19129**

We have been running our real estate business since 2000. We have been legal, good landlords and have kept some tenants for years. Our first tenant raised her son at our property from the time he was 5 years old until he graduated high school. We offer our tenants clean, solid houses. Please keep the real estate taxes in line so we can continue to offer reasonable rents.

— **Margaret B. • 19147**

I've run my business for 15 years and BIRT be crazy

— **Chris A. • IT & Tech Support • 19123**

I'm still a newer business owner. This tax makes it extremely difficult to keep a standard living while continuing to help my clients . Many of us are doing meaningful work, and this tax is setting us back.

— **Caroline O. • 19147**

New business, getting out of unsustainable contracts from unethical business owners. Trying to serve the community and also be able to afford a home and maybe children one day. Taxes are already insanely high. Small businesses that are built from passionate people sharing love in the city cannot afford more taxes. It's insulting to treat community members this way.

— **Giavanna C. • Mental Health Services • 19122**

I am a gig worker and opened a business 2.5 years ago. I am in the growing stages of getting a business off the ground. I also have a child in daycare and I was not anticipating this high of tax payments to be made and this surprise increase has made it that I am unable to pay my credit card bills. Those credit card bills carry a hefty fine for being late. I applied for the free tax prep offered through the city only to have an accountant that was very disorganized and I felt that I would be paying more in the end if I continued to use their services and decided to hire an accountant on my own and discontinued the free service the city offered that was not helpful.

— **patricia d.** • **19121**

11 years

— **Cynthia C.** • **Social Work** • **19147**

I'm a business owner of a tax firm and the gig workers are unfairly paying so much tax. I particularly think high school students with summer jobs that receive a 1099 shouldn't be paying BIRT at all.

— **Jessica D.** • **Accounting & Bookkeeping** • **19152**

The BIRT tax is a gross way to repay folks for creating small businesses in the city of Philadelphia. I shouldn't have to consider leaving Philadelphia to avoid being crushed with taxes as someone who works for and by myself.

— **Samantha S.** • **19125**

The end of the BIRT exemption really impacted me financially due to the hefty tax bill I owed. I am not against paying my taxes in order to contribute to the city, but I am disappointed and frustrated that small business owners have to bear the brunt of this tax bill while big corporations can take advantage of loopholes to avoid giving back to the city.

— **Kyra S.** • **Counseling & Therapy** • **19147**

I started my business in January 2020. I've weathered the pandemic and continued to evolve my business to meet the changing needs of my clients and customers. However, when we tax smaller businesses more than larger businesses, as a city we're reducing the incentives to be nimble and innovative.

— **Kara L.** • **19148**

It's hard enough out here for a freelancer, this is overtly burdensome to those of us who make so little already.

— **Tory N.** • **Prop Styling** • **19133**

The film industry is EXPENSIVE ENOUGH. Artists and filmmakers are EXPLOITED ENOUGH. Keep our resources in our pockets and YOUR economy gets better! We will create experiences, document legacy, and reinvest in the community, creating authentic culture with this resource. Let the people decide how to spend their hard earned money.

— **Lydia C.** • **Videography & Film** • **19144**

I make below the poverty level as a single mother and pay a higher tax rate than COMCAST.

— **Stephanie J.** • **Massage Therapy** • **19133**

The BIRT was on the verge of being phased out and the removal of the \$100k exclusion for small businesses is a slap in the face. The removal tells small businesses that the City of Philadelphia is not small business friendly.

— **Holly H.** • **Retail** • **19125**

I would prefer to not move my business outside of Philadelphia, but I will have to if BIRT continues

— **Sam S.** • **19128**

Now more than ever we need policies that support individual workers and small business owners. They are the lifeblood of our neighborhoods and our local economy. Saving the city money while also extending relief to entrepreneurs in our local area is a no-brainer.

— **Sean H. • IT & Tech Support • 19128**

I started my business 25 years ago

— **Bob P. • retail food • 19147**

I've seen some of the best people in healthcare and trades who have served their communities for years recently go out of business because of large corporations with inferior services and products - and no real ties to the local community in which they operate - beat these smaller businesses with lower prices. Small local businesses run by people who care about and live in the local communities in which they serve - are the foundation of society. I'm trying to grow my new business into a sustainable therapy practice that supports the local community. Mental health and wellness is more important than ever.

— **Adam K. • Mental Health Services • 19144**

I work for several vibrant and key small businesses, and watch them struggle with city taxes. Everyone pays their fair share gladly. But its hurtful to have to pay 100% to the the next year. Also, the exemption helps offset the the fact that city income is taxed very high.

— **Dawn B. • Administration • 19147**

For all of those affected.

— **Tara A. • 19055**

While not the fault of city council or mayor, not enough was done to prevent the damage caused by the elimination of the BIRT exemption. My BIRT increased by over \$5000 compared to last filing.

— **Courtland W. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19148**

I've owned my business in Philadelphia for several years, and having to pay even more taxes in an already heavily taxed city is a huge burden on my business. Small businesses and gig workers in Philadelphia don't deserve to be slapped with a tax higher than corporations when we keep the city's economy alive and thriving.

— **Cindy L. • 19147**

The attack on small businesses is predatory and disgusting. Small businesses work tirelessly around the clock to make a living and provide for themselves and their community while facing countless fees thrown at them just to be able to operate. This nonsense cuts into their bottom line and impacts what they are able to provide. 3% taken from every card transaction, 8% sales tax on each sale. This is not the group of businesses that need 5% taken from them. Take \$5000 from someone who makes \$100,000 will result in raised prices making local grown and created food less accessible to the community.

— **Jeanette • Farmers' Market • 19103**

I own Natty Contrera Artistry and Mango Marketing Co. I owe twice as much as I did last year and made less money. This is hurting small businesses that want to help Philadelphia grow.

— **Natalie C. • Hair & Beauty • 19146**

To support independent contractors in Philadelphia who serve children with special needs

— **Nadine M. • Tutoring & Education • 19038**

It's an important issue that deserves attention

— **Debra H.** • 19148

Because this is effecting all of us

— **Katherine m.** • 19121

I've run my business in Philly for over 17 years. The BIRT tax is a major deterrent to being a business in the city. Small businesses like mine are the backbone of our local economy and staples of our communities. This tax is an enormous financial burden on businesses that have proven their grit, determination, and dedication to our communities. We add to the value of living in Philadelphia and should be treated with respect. This tax will make it difficult for these staples within neighborhoods to remain. Remove gross profit tax from businesses with incomes under 100,000!!

— **Jennifer C.** • **healthcare** • 19125

I have run my small business for 20 years. the new Brit taxes are further threatening my small business with a big jump in expenses. It is already bearily making it with all the regulations and fees.

— **Deborah H.** • **Real Estate** • 19132

I have run my small business for 20 years. the new Brit taxes are further pressuring my sustainability as a business.

— **Steve H.** • **Real Estate** • 19132

4 year old business helping to revitalize Port Richmond. Trying to support my family and my children, and my employees.

— **Madison H.** • **Jewelry** • 19134

Supporting small businesses in my town of Fishtown Philadelphia.

— **Reyno B.** • 19125

I've been in this industry in Philadelphia 13 years, and opened my shop 4 years ago. It's getting harder and harder to be an independent barber or small business owner in this city

— **Vincent C.** • **Barbering & Hair Care** • 19125

To protect myself and my business from unnecessary changes

— **Miriam S.** • 19066

I've worked for to build my business for the past 9 years and finally got to a place where I could afford needed medical care and maybe even take a nice vacation. I was so proud of myself and feeling hopeful about my financial future. I have no safety net, it's just me. All of that changed with this change in taxes and being squeezed on all sides economically this year. I wish Philadelphia had offered some actual support if this change was inevitable. Surely other relief could be offered.

— **Colette G.** • **Counseling & Therapy** • 19147

I am just starting to build a business. In the planning stages. And it disheartens me to know how much small businesses will be taxed. There has to be a balance.

— **Amanda S.** • 19114

I run a business here and while we make over the threshold anyway, taxing on gross receipts is an absurd policy. Remove the rampant grift and fraud in the system before you come for my livelihood.

— **Stephen C.** • **Marketing & PR** • **19125**

To help support other small businesses also effected by this raise in the BIRT tax threshold

— **Amanda M.** • **Massage Therapy** • **19134**

Small business owner that cannot reasonably afford this new tax. Taxes are so high for small business owners already. This will put us all out of business. I won't be surprised if you see a HIGH number of businesses leaving Philly or shutting down this year.

— **Nicole S.** • **19145**

I'm disabled and unable to sustain full time work starting my own business is my only option to pay my bills. I shouldn't be paying at this rate while major business skirt taxes through incentive programs and loopholes. Small business entrepreneurship can help Philly thrive and attract bigger businesses to contribute more.

— **Meridith B.** • **19123**

As a native of Philadelphia we love our one on one shops that are run by smaller business owners it builds community Why would you tax the small business as much as you tax the big business that can easily pay this amount it's not supportive

— **Brandi L.** • **19143**

It's already hard enough to be an arts entrepreneur in Philadelphia lifting up the entire community with the work we do to tell great stories about our creatives here. Philadelphia continues to punish small business owners, who are the lifeblood of the city.

— **Heather B.** • **Media** • **19147**

To support friends and the arts of independent contractors

— **Natalie S.** • **19147**

I am signing this petition because I am one of the people this impacts. As a self-employed professional and small business owner in Philadelphia, I work hard to create income, serve others, and keep moving forward. Like many independent workers, I do not have the cushion or resources of a large corporation. Every dollar matters. It helps pay for housing, utilities, food, business expenses, and the basic stability needed to keep contributing to this city. This tax change makes it harder for people like me to stay in business and sustain a living. It feels unfair that individuals, sole proprietors, gig workers, and mom-and-pop businesses can end up carrying a heavier tax burden than corporations. I am asking City Council and Council President Johnson to hold a hearing and bring Bill No. 251026 to a vote. Philadelphia should stand with the people who work hard, hustle, serve their communities, and help keep this city alive.

— **Tina M.** • **19106**

I barely make enough as it is to pay my bills and survive, so paying an additional and unexpected few thousand dollars in BIRT and NPT taxes really hurt me. Completely wiped out any savings I had and now I'm scared for any emergencies that pop up.

— **Vered G.** • **Real Estate** • **19134**

Small businesses have it tough enough as it is

— **Joe L.** • **Writing & Journalism** • **19134**

I don't make enough money to pay more to the city than the wage tax.

— **Robert S.** • **legal** • **19148**

Taxes are too high risking my small business's survival

— **Walid B.** • **19145**

I got slapped with a huge unexpected tax bill which puts projected house projects on hold. So I cannot hire other small business owners because of this tax.

— **Patrick H.** • **Real Estate** • **19147**

Small businesses are the backbone of Philadelphia. A common sense tax code has been needed for a long time.

— **Daniela A.** • **19147**

I e run a business for over 10 years and the tax is killing me

— **Jovida B.** • **Finance** • **19131**

Small businesses are what bring character to the city. We need to prioritize helping them succeed.

— **Sarah K.** • **19128**

The old tax waiver helped small businesses survive as they grow. Removing the BIRT tax waiver made it that much harder on people with modest incomes. City officials didn't fight for small businesses when challenged by Zoll Medical Corp meanwhile big corporations constantly get tax breaks.

— **Christie E.** • **Mental Health Services** • **19146**

In support of regular Philadelphia citizens trying to make a living by having a small business.

— **Kathy C.** • **19148**

I am concerned about my local economy! Some of my favorite places are small businesses, and some of my favorite people are independent contractors or own their own small business. We need policy changes and tax reform!

— **Kelly F.** • **19146**

Business taxes are extraordinarily high in Philadelphia. Higher than most cities with the burden largely levied on small businesses. The structure is holding the entire city back. Small businesses are especially the foundation of Philadelphia's vibe and attraction.

— **Jeanne W.** • **Real Estate** • **19125**

The BIRT exemption helped over 65,000 business invest more into their communities and businesses. Small businesses and artisans deserve a chance to thrive

— **Cat W.** • **Alterations & Tailoring** • **19122**

We are incurring way too many taxes as of late. Rents are ridiculous. Something needs to change. This isn't NYC or LA. Philadelphia needs to encourage people to want to live here and own businesses; not chase them away. We aren't a city that has great weather, and we have a lot of crime. We need something to encourage people to move here, and lower taxes can do that.

— **Michelle M.** • 19148

My business is still growing and will not be able to sustain with the BIRT tax in addition to other state/municipal/city taxes. I have come through the city of Philadelphia for both school and college and I feel my business deserves the chance to maintain here as well. Otherwise, I will have to move it elsewhere.

— **Lailah C.** • **Graphic Design & Visual Art** • 19138

I'm very concerned about the impact BIRT is going to have on small businesses throughout the city & in my community. Philadelphia is a city that thrives on small businesses & we should be supporting them, not harming them. BIRT will cause unnecessary hardship for so many..there is a better way. City Council needs to work w/them to do this.

— **Beth G.** • 19147

Just started my business.

— **Crystal F.** • **Beauty** • 19139

I'm an employee at the navy yard and started my own business. I believe the city's budget and tax codes do not make sense and require major improvements.

— **Crystal P.** • 19112

I'm a disabled person supporting disabled people. Small businesses make our communities work!

— **Mattia M.** • 19147

I can barely afford to keep the doors open as is. I have 20 employees depending on me to put food on their tables.

— **Katherine w.** • **Pet Care & Dog Walking** • 19145

I'm a sole proprietor of a business that barely makes enough to support my child. I'm often qualifying for aid services based on the year. I cannot afford another huge tax and to run my business. I understand that you posted the change of this tax, but it doesn't mean that small businesses could afford to prepare for it. Are large businesses being taxed at an appropriate rate or is there another way to make up this income for the city?

— **Meredith N.** • **Videography & Film** • 19125

Taxes are really high for making very little

— **Ross M.** • **Health** • 19147

BIRT exemption should exist for those making under 40k

— **Leslie S.** • 19146

Many of my friends that own small businesses are struggling. I am concerned that businesses I support are going to go out of business this year!

— **Chris H.** • 19128

Philly should support small business growth. I feel like I am drowning in taxes.

— **HOPE V. • Interior designer • 19143**

BIRT is a terrible model. It incentivizes people to move their businesses outside of the city and then penalizes those who want to keep their business here in Philly.

— **Ryan C. • Event Planning • 19145**

My husband has a small business in the city - our family was impacted by this change this year.

— **Meredith W. • 19146**

I'm a one-person business with minimal margins in Philadelphia for many years. The large tax increase Will make it difficult for me to continue.

— **Jim L. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19147**

Twenty years ago I explained the first-hand negative impact of BIRT on sole proprietors to members of city council while shooting a national news piece with them. All these years later, we STILL don't have a permanent fix. It's time!

— **Kaci V. • TV Production • 19147**

The fact that sole proprietors have been subject to the BIRT has been a bone of contention for me for years. We are essentially our own employees and should be taxed at the same rate as any normal employee: the city wage tax based on our net income from the business. The BIRT should be reserved for businesses with more than 1 (one) employee!

— **Eric M. • Real Estate • 19130**

I want Philadelphia to support their small businesses. I believe this bill will force more and more small businesses into the counties, hurting our city and creating less accessibility for Philadelphians. There's no reason to punish small businesses that are trying to grow because of pressure from large out of state law firms. This feels like the wealthy harming the average Philadelphian and I would hope our city government has greater loyalty to its own people than it is currently demonstrating.

— **Amy M. • Mental Health Services • 19128**

the change has significant impact on my income

— **Joshua Z. • Real Estate • 19123**

I've been in business in Philadelphia for over 24 years as a sole proprietor. This current tax burden makes my private practice unsustainable. Please pass this bill so that my business and may others can continue to thrive (and pay taxes).

— **Rachel A. • Psychotherapy • 19130**

In the next 5 years the only businesses that will be able to thrive in Philadelphia will be corporate giants, if this tax continues the way it currently is.

— **olivia m. • Lifestyle brand • 19125**

I'm an independent contractor directly affected by this law

— **Phyllis A. • Real Estate • 19128**

I've been a full-time licensed real estate Agent & landlord here since 1984.

— **Neil K. • Real Estate • 19118**

killing me with more taxes and less opportunity

— **melissa m. • retail • 19148**

My husband runs a small business and this hit us hard. We had to use a large part of our savings to cover the costs especially since we were forced to prepay 2027

— **Melissa R. • 19128**

This affected my business on a very personal level. I, along with so many other small business owners I know, feel this is a predatory tax law that is not in the best interests of the people of Philadelphia.

— **Rose C. • 19128**

I've had my pet sitting business since 2010. It's just me, I do not make 6 figures. These taxes are brutal for the "little guys" who have a small business. I'm just trying to live.

— **Drubin D. • Pet Sitter • 19147**

Large corporations are getting a pass while the rest of us are struggling!

— **Sarah B. • Writing & Journalism • 19118**

The birt tax is affecting the small business I work for, and many other friends and acquaintances who work as independent contractors or run their own small business. It's become more difficult for businesses to afford expenses, including payroll, let alone periodic wage raises to employees. Independent contractors struggle enough as it is to find a steady stream of income, now the city is demanding a huge percentage of their net income. It's not just unfair- it's cruel!

— **Emily M. • Skilled Worker • 19145**

Small business owners struggle too much already. Philadelphia should make it easier/ cheaper to run a small business, not harder pr more expensive. Small businesses are what makes a city unique, interesting, soulful and culturally relevant.

— **Sochi L. • Real Estate • 19119**

Both my husband and I work as independent contractors. We would consider moving out of Philadelphia if taxes go up even more than they already are at this point.

— **Shanna A. • 19144**

Support the effort

— **janet F. • Real Estate • 19119**

Many of my friends run small businesses, and it's ridiculous to learn about how much bureaucracy they face - especially as compared to all of the mega-corporations who get tax breaks, city grants, and so much more from our mayor and local government.

— **Connor D. • 19147**

I'm a sole proprietor. Not having the BIRT exemption was a huge financial hardship this year. I cannot continue to run my nutrition counseling business in the city if this act isn't passed.

— **Lisa L. • Registered Dietitian Nutritionist • 19147**

The increase at a time when we are facing so much means I cannot operate my business in Philadelphia anymore

— **Morgan J. • 19144**

I'm a retired Single Proprietor who stands behind this petition. We are taxing hard working Business Owners a ridiculous amount of money, while allowing Corporations to go Tax Free. Most Single Proprietor Business Owners are just squeaking by, but providing a service for their customers. I support this petition.

— **Denise C. • 19148**

For every reason outlined here. The BIRT reinstatement is outrageous and certainly unfair. I'm a one-person operation who has worked on some fairly high visibility projects right here in Philadelphia. I love my independence but I'm planning to close up next month, and figure out something or somewhere else.

— **Eliot M. • Interior Design • 19145**

This is an important issue to address in Philly.

— **Neil D. • Real Estate • 19118**

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— **Jonnese G. • Personal Training & Fitness • 19401**

I am about to start a small business but know thing makes me hesitant. This taxation discourages young , creative , driven people. Why keep businesses "underground" when people would be happy to pay reasonable tax to the city that gave them that perfect storefront? Or perfect studio?

— **Brooke A. • Restaurant & Hospitality • 19125**

Im an independent contractor and this affects me greatly.

— **Jessica S. • 19148**

I'm an independent business owner. I don't have employees and do everything on my own. This is an additional burden.

— **Hannah Y. • Photography • 19138**

Small business owner for 10 years and daughter of small business owners.

— **Megan A. • Veterinary hospital • 19147**

Philadelphia

— **Nile L. • Business Consulting • 19139**

Realtor in Philly since 2008...

— **Julie R. • Real Estate • 19382**

Many of our contractors are affected by this. I'm worried that I'm going to lose the talent that has been easy to find in Philadelphia historically because all of the artists will leave. I've spoken with many artists who have contemplated moving out of the city because of this tax, it's a nightmare. Losing our artistic talent in the city would be a disaster.

— Sarah m. • Tutoring & Education • 19125

I've run my business here since 1979

— Louise D. • 19006

Saddling people with a surprise extra tax bill isn't right, people need time to prepare at the very least. But it seems to me that this will have a disproportionate impact on the people least likely to have extra funds

— Rebecca P. • Research • 19139

Don't want to move out of the city but I and most of my fellow business owners will.

— Donna Z. • 19122

The BIRT tax is more than my whole state of PA tax!! I don't make enough money to afford this, and would have to be on a payment plan that would inevitably snowball year after year if I remain in Philly. Strongly considering moving to escape this extra tax if necessary.

— Brianna G. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19128

Our community is stronger with small business and if I wanted to start a new business this would prevent me from starting it here in philadelphia in the future.

— Jason M. • 19119

This creates an undue tax burden on taxpayers

— Luise A. • 19123

Many of my most treasured businesses within philadelphia are SMALL businesses, and SMALL businesses are what make philadelphia the beautiful vibrant amazing city it is. These taxes will drive philadephia-based small business owners out of the city, if not out of the state of PA entirely. Tax the top 1% and get your heads out of the ground.

— R C. • 19026

I've run my business in this city since 2017. I offer low-cost integrative medical care, and I treasure making this something affordable to low and middle-income people - not just something available to the wealthy. However, because of the BIRT, my annual tax bill increased by 110% this past year. If this continues, I'll either be forced to increase what I charge my patients or to leave the city. This would make my services unaffordable and/or inaccessible to the very people I have been serving.

— Marie W. • Healthcare • 19148

Don't tax small businesses into non-existence. Small businesses will end up shutting down or leaving the city.

— Rachel S. • 19144

This has significantly negatively impacted my life.

— Noel P. • Counseling & Therapy • 19145

I'm a 2013 graduate of the Former University of the Arts, and I have been living and contributing to the economy as a freelance Illustrator since 2014. I have relied on my freelance income as my sole income since 2019. My take home is small and my regular taxes are a burden on me, with the BIRT it is yet another hardship. People like me who have been contributing to the economy of this city by way of gig work, independent contract work, or self employment deserve to be heard and considered with regard to how we are taxed. We live on razor thin margins and the last thing we want is to feel run out of our own city because we can't afford to live or work here anymore.

— **Heather V. • Freelance Illustrator • 19148**

For my sister who is a hairstylist and needs to make some money!!

— **Abigail D. • 19102**

I'm a sole proprietor (LPC) in the suburbs who wants to support my colleagues in the city.

— **Megan B. • Counseling & Therapy • 19026**

I started a small construction business after being in the industry for 12 years and seeing how many contractors operate their business poorly and corruptly. I live and work in Philly and it's becoming increasingly difficult to keep operating in a responsible way with rising costs and BIRT. I would love to grow my business in Philly and hire more home grown talent but adding more and more costs on top in an increasingly difficult city to operate is becoming discouraging.

— **Colin L. • Construction & General Contracting • 19147**

I'm signing in support of others in addition to myself who are likely to be negatively impacted

— **Esther G. • 19119**

Supporting the folks making their own livelihoods.

— **Vanessa G. • Software as a service • 19147**

Real estate agent for 7 years

— **Amy C. • 19118**

I grew up in Philly, I've had a business since 2021 and never thought of having it anywhere else. Losing the exemption caused me to have to pay nearly 250% more than I have before and it's got me thinking of leaving home forever. Do the right thing, City Hall.

— **Kyle C. • Videography & Film • 19121**

It's too much for a small business owner.

— **Terrie L. • Wellness • 19122**

Another small business by BIRT tax!

— **Jessica W. • Pet Care & Dog Walking • 19143**

I owed an extra thousand dollars on my taxes this year even though I made less money than I did the previous year.

— **Jessica G. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19148**

This tax makes it impossible to live as an independent business owner in this city.

— **Jamie D. • Visual Arts & Muralism • 19145**

I am planning to buy into a franchise, and I want to be in the city limits.... But this may change that decision.

— **Troy R.** • 19119

I've run my business for the last four years, providing a great experience for folks wanting to play dodgeball. I'm already competing against giants that run multiple sports, and my profit margins are very small. This will definitely impact me.

— **Samantha S.** • Sports • 19128

Counselors provide essential health care to populations in need. A vast majority of mental health providers are underpaid, overworked, and beholden to varying reimbursement rates from insurance organization. To destabilize a counselor's source of income by increasing their taxes will destabilize mental health services to Philly's most sensitive groups which will undoubtedly have systemic impacts for our city. Please reconsider reinstating the tax exemption for these essential workers.

— **Nicole P.** • Counseling & Therapy • 19063

We can't have strong community without independent businesses - and this tax is a death knoll.

— **Adrienne O.** • 19144

I've been in business for 15 years, it's just me, doing my best to serve my clients and support my family. Things are hard enough for small businesses right now, we are not where the city should be looking for more tax income.

— **Rachel U.** • 19146

Small businesses are the backbone of our city. We cannot burden them like this when there are MUCH BIGGER FISH we could fry.

— **Walt Z.** • 19123

I would like the opportunity to own a small business someday and any pressure off the people who work to create an economy not run of corporate monopolies is important.

— **Gretel S.** • 19148

My business income fluctuates significantly every year. In fact, I expect to earn less than half in 2026 what I earned in 2025. Having to not only pay this tax but to pay an estimated amount a year out is making me wonder why I'm even self-employed.

— **Jillian I.** • 19148

I run my business and can not afford to pay even more taxes.

— **Sean R.** • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19148

I'm a small business owner and the financial impact of this tax is a struggle. We already pay enough!

— **Jenna S.** • Personal Training & Fitness • 19146

I'm a freelancer and am opening an official business soon. Taxes are already an incredible burden every year, let alone every quarter for businesses and this is targeting the wrong individuals/businesses that need support, not penalties.

— **Kaitlin W.** • 1099 / Freelance (Other) • 19147

I am a freelance comic book artist/illustrator and a sole proprietor living in the city. The removal of the \$100,000 BIRT exemption for the 2025 tax year caught me and even my CPA a bit by surprise. I was thankfully able to pay it from some of the savings I have in my business account. But it was definitely a hit to my finances I wasn't anticipating. I owed ~\$1,800 that I'd otherwise be spending on new equipment, or possibly even groceries and other bills if work and payments get a little infrequent as I'm not always paid every month. The \$100,000 BIRT exemption was a huge boon to people like me and I find it unconscionable that myself and my fellow artists and sole proprietors/single-member LLC's who are often in precarious financial situations are being forced to pay even more in taxes when we're already being squeezed to our limit. This needs to be remedied in a way that restores the \$100,000 exemption or something similar.

— Jason P. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19147

We do not support the taxation

— Lauren S. • medical • 19148

I'm a new social work therapist and a sole proprietor - with insurance reimbursement being quite low in the state of PA, my salary is already below what a person with a master's degree should be earning. An additional tax on an already low salary requires an even greater financial burden on people providing services that are, frankly, essential to our community. Please exempt individual workers, sole proprietors, and solo-LLC owners to be exempt from this highly destructive and counter productive tax. Perhaps consider levying higher taxes on Comcast or Penn instead?

— Sarah S. • Counseling & Therapy • 19147

This effects my community and marginalizes small business owners.

— Robert S. • 19144

Philadelphia should welcome small businesses and not make it so that it's not financially viable for them to exist.

— Lea S. • 19117

My City of Philadelphia taxes this year increased 207% (since 2027 needed to be prepaid). My business was not expecting to get hit this hard with taxes. With quarterly payments due again in July, small businesses can barely keep afloat. I ask- where will this money be going to help improve the lives of Philadelphians? At this time, myself and many other small business owners are reconsidering if it is worth being a small business in the City of Philadelphia.

— Michael G. • Painting & Finishing • 19128

Because these taxes are outrageous I've had this business for 25 yrs and never had to pay this much

— Tracy H. • Cleaning & Janitorial Services • 19129

Concerned citizen

— Andrea M. • 19143

My daughter is a small business owner in Philadelphia and is not fair to her or her business

— Dawn Z. • 21043

I care about my fellow Philadelphians and stand with people over corporations every day. I have friends who are artists who will horribly impacted by this and am concerned for them as well as those I don't know personally.

— Jillian L. • 19145

I believe in small businesses and want them to have the support they need in Philadelphia

— **Megan K.** • **19143**

I am an independent sole proprietor of a therapy practice, and this change in tax law will directly and seriously affect me.

— **Abigail H.** • **Psychotherapy** • **19119**

I love this city and this tax only hurts small businesses - it shouldn't be a burden to be here and work here!

— **Madison B.** • **Photography** • **19121**

I frequent the small businesses in my neighborhood and would like to continue to do so.

— **Erin P.** • **19148**

I know many people who run small businesses in Philly and am concerned that they will be forced to close businesses and/ move out of Philly

— **Ellen S.** • **21014**

We love small Philly businesses!

— **Kim s.** • **19134**

Small business should be protected

— **Abigail N.** • **Hair & Beauty** • **19122**

I've run my business for 6 years and finally at a point where I am proud to be a recognized name and business and finally be able to support my family! The new changes to BIRT are unfair after all the taxes we pay as business owners and community members of Philadelphia.

— **Harley M.** • **Photography** • **19104**

Been running this business for 4 years... Moved to the city 3 years ago. This past year has been so hard. Here to support local businesses and should not be penalized to live in the city and support the local economy since I could have stayed in the suburbs for a much simpler and less expensive life outside of the BIRT tax scenario. Here to support Philly small businesses and work together!

— **Alena S.** • **Videography & Film** • **19147**

I've been a landlord on the city for over 25yrs and I am seriously considering selling my properties and buying elsewhere because I can't afford all the additional taxes the city keeps adding without raising the rents

— **Qiana M.** • **Real Estate** • **19150**

I am proud to work here, and love contributing to this talented artistic community. But I'm being priced out of staying.

— **Kevin C.** • **Illustration** • **19123**

Supporting my partner who is a 1099 therapist

— **Kevin M.** • **UPS** • **19130**

I simply cannot afford to be a single mom paying taxes that are out of my bracket.

— **Kanthia I.** • **Nail Technology** • **19046**

I love Philly and want to keep doing business here.

— **Marta R.** • **Social Media & Content Creation** • **19107**

I adore the restaurant and the owner of this unique business, as well as many other small businesses I frequent in Chestnut Hill as I lived there for 30+ years. WHY are you taxing small businesses/vs corporations???? This is counterproductive and pure stupidity!!!!

— **Donna D.** • **Restaurant & Hospitality** • **19002**

My income is so small and this BIRT tax eats it up.

— **Kate M.** • **Graphic Design & Visual Art** • **19147**

All of my income is through independent contractor so I was involved in having to pay this tax. The income is incredibly minimum.

— **Martha C.** • **Dance & Movement** • **19119**

Birt tax exemption reform

— **Holly M.** • **Psychology** • **19144**

This seems like a much more supportive situation for people with smaller businesses.

— **Margaret L.** • **Writing & Journalism** • **19143**

I am a small business owner that is impacted by this tax increase to the point of unsustainability; I would like to continue to serve the people of Philadelphia, and the taxes need to change.

— **Emily M.** • **19130**

Im a new business and getting started with this tax is making it that much harder to succeed

— **Erica M.** • **19148**

I am starting a business, and feeling like maybe I should not have invested in Philadelphia as it doesn't seem to support small business.

— **Marisha S.** • **art education** • **19144**

the elimination of the BIRT exemption makes my already very thin margins even thinner. i pride myself on providing a living wage to every person i employ and would like to be able to continue to do that.

— **Bethany R.** • **Visual Arts & Muralism** • **19143**

It's hard enough for small businesses to thrive with increasing rents and costs. The least the city could do is support them. Without small businesses the culture of our city shrivels down to nothing. Support our community!!

— **Rae S.** • **19143**

As an independent contractor I do not feel like paying more taxes. Also I don't support this tax because it's regressive, not progressive. We should be taxing people who actually have money.

— **Vashti B.** • **19146**

This is crazy to consider, and I fear for the many vibrant small businesses that would be affected by this change. I hope the councilmembers will do the right thing for the city by bringing it to a vote.

— **Tara P.** • 19146

To support small businesses that keep the city vibrant

— **Bonnie E.** • 19103

I am signing to help small business continue in Philadelphia and provide a foundation for a successful dynamic environment for Philadelphia

— **robert a.** • 19130

Supporter and employee

— **Tracy G.** • **Personal Training & Fitness** • 19147

Small businesses in Philadelphia keep me healthy, happy, and able to provide for my daughter. Sole proprietorships should be able afford to stay in the city!

— **Charlotte M.** • 19103

I support small businesses

— **Jane G.** • 19130

I value the local independent businesses that make my community strong and vibrant. A tax code that recognizes these as small-scale, individually-operated entities makes sense for their viability.

— **Paula F.** • 19130

This is an unfair tax that has significant impact on the well being of people who work in and improve the life of city dwellers.

— **Marlyn V.** • 19130

I believe in supporting small businesses

— **Heidi** • 19130

I'm brand new in my business and I want it to have the best chance for success

— **Alicia M.** • **Personal Training & Fitness** • 19129

I've run a tax practice in Philadelphia since 2017 and the new BIRT law has severely impacted my small business clients and already has people talking about leaving the city to avoid it.

— **Zach C.** • **Tax and Accounting Services** • 19121

To show my respect for the people who would be positively affected by this change.

— **Carl B.** • 19130

I've been self employed for 16 years and employ 4 Philadelphia residents.

— **Walter M.** • **Accounting & Bookkeeping** • 19125

I'm a new business just trying to make it out here!

— **Michelle C.** • **19148**

We just opened in November and already have had new taxes added such as an occupancy tenant tax that jumped from around \$200 a year to \$147 a month and now this. Enough is enough.

— **Robert R.** • **Private Mail Center** • **19148**

I'm a tiny business. Tax the big guys.

— **Erika B.** • **Food Service & Catering** • **19148**

I am very grateful for all the incredible customers who have supported our farm over the last 15+ years, but our business could be much more profitable if we sold our produce elsewhere.

— **Landon J.** • **Agriculture** • **19503**

Philadelphia is made vibrant by its small businesses, but the city needs to support the conditions that allow these businesses to thrive. Overtaxing will only hurt the city.

— **Natanya A.** • **Theater & Performing Arts** • **19144**

I am finding it very hard to be a small business in Philadelphia. Every day is a struggle. Small business is what makes this city great. We need support not more taxes.

— **Tara A.** • **Garden Center** • **19147**

Philadelphia is my city and, as I'm preparing to move back, I make a considerable amount of my livelihood via an sole-ownership LLC. The BIRT alteration threatens that livelihood and that of thousands of working people. Please consider this amendment on our behalf.

— **Ryan S.** • **Museum Professional** • **19127**

I am directly affected by this issue.

— **Robert B.** • **19148**

To Whom It May Concern, I'm writing to highlight the deeply concerning and rapidly growing burden of taxes and local fees on small businesses. In addition to federal, state, and local taxes, we pay an additional \$667 annual Passyunk BID assessment, \$500.00 trash removal tax, and a \$147 monthly Landlord and Occupancy tax—totaling over \$2,400 per year before other obligations. Now the BRIT Tax? These ongoing costs, along with compliance demands, take time and resources away from running and growing my business. I ask that the cumulative impact on small businesses be carefully considered. Thank you for your time. Sincerely,

— **Dan D.** • **Mail Center** • **19148**

The extra tax payment takes away from my already low-income revenue.

— **Luis G.** • **Food Service & Catering** • **19147**

We need to support small businesses because they are critical to making Philadelphia the amazing city that it is.

— **Peter K.** • **19147**

I can understand a case for increases in taxes - but it is galling when taxes for small businesses under \$100,000 are going up while Billionaires and giant corporate entities in the city do not pay their fair share. I am one of thousands of artists whose work makes Philadelphia a thriving cultural center. Large corporations benefit enormously from being located in and drawing employees to live and work in a vibrant city center. I am proud to call Philadelphia home, and to claim Philadelphia when I tour my work domestically and internationally. But a more hostile environment to small creators like me pushes us to the margins or out of the city entirely, while large and massively profitable operations leech subsidies out of a city while minimizing any and all contribution to the life and humanity of the place.

— **Yannick T. • Theater & Performing Arts • 19104**

This tax cost me and my businesses a lot this year. It needs to go.

— **Jeffrey B. • Graphic Design & Visual Art • 19148**

As a disabled woman-owned therapy practice in Philadelphia, I serve people with disabilities, many of whom rely on Medicaid through CBH. Because CBH requires providers to maintain a physical office while reimbursing at rates far below private insurance, my practice already operates under significant financial strain. The City's BIRT adds another layer of pressure, making it harder for small providers like me to continue serving underserved communities. This directly affects the sustainability of care for Philadelphians who already face substantial barriers to accessing mental health services.

— **Shannon R. • Mental Health Services • 19046**

It is a major added expense that is hitting a segment of the business industry that already has a major burden of expenses related to taxes, city fees... on top of being in an industry with extreme rising costs in labor and cost of goods.

— **Vincent S. • Restaurant & Hospitality • 19147**

I've been in business here in Philly for 19 years, and it keeps getting more and more difficult to operate here, financially. Please help us!

— **Rachel K. • Food Service & Catering • 19145**

I love Philadelphia, but my business can be run two miles away, nearby, and I won't have to pay BIRT (\$4,400 last year). We are being double taxed. The whole point of the sole proprietorship design is to be pass-through and not taxed at the business level. The BIRT defeats the point. We already pay our fair NPT tax which, incidentally, is not seemingly used to create a reliable and working public transit system so no one who lives here can get to my business in the first place reliably. Ultimately, if the BIRT doesn't change, NJ is waiting with open arms, which I don't want to do, but may have to. Lastly, under the current BIRT outlook, 2028's entire year's BIRT estimate will be owed in April of the year the money is supposed to be earned, which should be illegal, and is most likely evil, but most charitably, some of the most idiotic buffoonery I've ever heard. Philly needs to retain and promote small businesses. Preposterous and easy to avoid taxes drive us out.

— **Joshua E. • 19146**

This has a big effect on what I can produce

— **Paul G. • Dance party • 19146**

I am an independent contractor and I do not own a business. Instead, I work for other businesses on a 1099 contract, which is industry standard since my work is inherently finite—I am a theatrical stage manager, and shows are only open for so long. Being taxed on my income as if it is business profit is hugely detrimental to me. I live under the poverty line and paid more than twice the amount of BIRT taxes this year than I did in state taxes. I am already being exploited under this system that refuses to classify me as an employee, and the BIRT tax is extra unfair on top of that.

— **Sophie K.** • **Theater & Performing Arts** • **19145**

Small businesses should be treated better and this BIRT tax is insane

— **Causha S.** • **Coaching and Consulting** • **19145**

I care about small businesses in Philly. They're an integral part of the city.

— **Stan H.** • **19130**

The elimination of the BIRT Exemption has disproportionately negatively affected Philadelphia small business owners. Larger corporations receive tax exemptions, abatements and other benefits, the small business owner receives nothing. The Northeast Philadelphia Small Business Alliance represents 1,600+ small business in the Northeast and we urge City Council to pass the introduced bill out of committee and to hold a general information hearing for implementation.

— **Patrick O.** • **Small Business Advocacy** • **19114**

I am a tax preparer and I have heard from my clients that this additional cost is crushing for their businesses.

— **Margaret M.** • **Bookkeeper** • **19144**